

Chapter 2: Needs Assessment

Mock Dissertation Chapter for Layout Reference

Note: This is a sample chapter written to show structure, flow, and formatting expectations for a dissertation needs assessment chapter. It is not intended to replace institution-specific formatting requirements or a final methods chapter approved by a dissertation chair.

Introduction

This chapter presents the needs assessment for a proposed residential reentry program designed for emerging adults involved in the justice system. The purpose of the needs assessment is to determine whether the proposed program addresses a meaningful service gap, to identify the clinical, educational, vocational, and reentry needs of the intended population, and to gather stakeholder input that can guide program design. In applied dissertation work, a needs assessment chapter often serves as the foundation for later recommendations, implementation planning, and evaluation design. Accordingly, this chapter outlines the proposed program, describes the focus and scope of the chapter, identifies participants included in the data collection process, explains recruitment and selection procedures, reviews informed consent procedures, presents quantitative and qualitative questions with a rationale for each, and describes the planned strategy for data analysis, validity, and trustworthiness.

The proposed needs assessment uses a mixed-methods approach. Quantitative data are included to provide structured information regarding perceived needs, barriers, service priorities, and program preferences. Qualitative data are included to capture nuance, lived experience, and stakeholder perspectives that may not emerge through fixed-response items alone. Together, these methods support a more complete understanding of the needs of emerging adults transitioning from residential or justice-related settings into the community.

Proposed Program

The proposed program is a residential facility designed for emerging adults approximately 18 to 25 years old who are transitioning from justice involvement, instability, or other high-risk life circumstances into greater community independence. The program is intended to support

desistance from offending and promote positive developmental outcomes by offering structured housing, case management, mental health support, psychoeducation, life-skills training, vocational preparation, educational support, and prosocial community integration.

The developmental period of emerging adulthood presents unique challenges and opportunities. Individuals in this age range are often navigating identity development, emotional regulation, employment instability, strained family relationships, trauma histories, and increased risk for criminal persistence when adequate supports are absent. A residential model may provide the structure and continuity needed to stabilize participants while still supporting autonomy, responsibility, and long-term reintegration. The needs assessment is therefore designed to determine what services are most needed, what barriers interfere with successful participation, and what program components stakeholders view as most critical to effectiveness.

Chapter Overview

This chapter covers the design of the needs assessment and the rationale for each major methodological component. First, it identifies the participants for two focus groups: one group composed of the target population and one group composed of professional stakeholders. Second, it describes recruitment strategies and participant selection criteria. Third, it outlines informed consent procedures. Fourth, it presents the proposed quantitative and qualitative questions and explains why each question is included. Finally, it reviews the plan for thematic analysis of qualitative data, descriptive analysis of quantitative responses, and procedures used to support validity and trustworthiness.

Participants

Focus Group 1: Emerging Adult Participants

The first focus group will consist of emerging adults who resemble the intended population for the proposed residential program. These participants may include individuals between the ages of 18 and 25 with histories of justice involvement, residential placement, probation or parole supervision, housing instability, or significant difficulty transitioning into independent adulthood. Including members of the target population is essential because they can provide

direct insight into unmet needs, barriers to service engagement, and features of programming that would feel supportive versus punitive or ineffective.

A target of six to eight participants is appropriate for the first focus group. This size is large enough to generate diverse perspectives while remaining small enough to allow each participant to contribute meaningfully. Participants should reflect a range of relevant experiences, including differences in gender, educational background, prior system involvement, and service history when feasible.

Focus Group 2: Professional Stakeholders

The second focus group will consist of professional stakeholders who work with justice-involved or high-risk emerging adults. These stakeholders may include mental health clinicians, case managers, probation or parole officers, residential staff, social workers, educators, vocational support providers, and administrators familiar with reentry or transitional service systems. This group is included because professionals can identify systemic gaps, common barriers to continuity of care, service coordination challenges, and practical considerations for implementation.

A target of six to eight professional participants is also appropriate for this focus group. Stakeholders should be selected based on their direct experience with the target population and their ability to comment on existing services, unmet needs, and realistic program design considerations.

Recruitment Strategies

Recruitment for the emerging adult focus group may occur through community agencies, outpatient clinics, probation-related programs, residential settings, educational support programs, or nonprofit organizations serving justice-involved youth and young adults. Recruitment materials may include flyers, email invitations distributed by partnering organizations, and brief announcements shared by trusted providers. Whenever possible, recruitment should occur through organizations with established rapport with the target population, as trust can influence willingness to participate.

Recruitment for the professional stakeholder focus group may occur through direct email invitation, professional networking, agency partnerships, and snowball sampling. Potential participants may be identified based on their job role, expertise, and familiarity with the service system relevant to emerging adults in transition.

Recruitment materials should clearly explain the purpose of the study, participation expectations, approximate time commitment, voluntary nature of participation, and any compensation offered if permitted. Language used in recruitment should be respectful, non-stigmatizing, and easy to understand.

Selection Criteria

Inclusion Criteria for Emerging Adults

Participants in the emerging adult focus group should:

1. Be between 18 and 25 years old.
2. Have a history relevant to the proposed program, such as justice involvement, residential placement, probation supervision, or substantial transition-related instability.
3. Be able to provide informed consent.
4. Be willing to discuss service needs and barriers in a group setting.
5. Be sufficiently fluent in the language used for the focus group or have approved language access supports available.

Exclusion Criteria for Emerging Adults

Emerging adults may be excluded if they are unable to provide informed consent, are in acute distress that would make participation clinically inappropriate, or present safety concerns that cannot be reasonably managed in a focus group setting.

Inclusion Criteria for Professional Stakeholders

Professional participants should:

1. Be at least 18 years old.
2. Have direct professional experience working with justice-involved or high-risk emerging adults.
3. Have sufficient knowledge of service delivery gaps, barriers, or program needs to contribute meaningfully to discussion.
4. Be willing to participate in a recorded focus group if recording is used.

Exclusion Criteria for Professional Stakeholders

Stakeholders may be excluded if they lack direct experience with the target population or are unable to provide informed consent.

Informed Consent

Informed consent should be obtained from all participants prior to data collection. Participants should receive a written consent form explaining the purpose of the needs assessment, what participation involves, expected duration, potential risks and benefits, voluntary nature of participation, confidentiality protections, and limits to confidentiality. The consent process should also explain whether the focus groups will be audio recorded and how recordings, notes, and transcripts will be stored and de-identified.

Because the topic may involve sensitive experiences related to justice involvement, trauma, housing instability, or mental health concerns, the consent form should make clear that participants may decline to answer any question and may withdraw at any time without penalty. Participants should also be informed that confidentiality in focus groups cannot be guaranteed in the same way it can be in individual interviews, because other group members will hear what is shared. For this reason, participants should be encouraged to respect the privacy of others and avoid disclosing identifying details outside the group.

If the study is affiliated with an academic institution, all consent procedures should align with Institutional Review Board requirements before recruitment begins.

Questions and Rationale

The needs assessment includes both quantitative and qualitative questions. Quantitative items are intended to identify patterns in service needs and priorities across participants. Qualitative questions are intended to provide richer context, clarify meaning, and allow participants to describe experiences in their own words.

Quantitative Questions for Emerging Adults

Participants may be asked to rate each item on a 5-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (*not at all important or strongly disagree*) to 5 (*extremely important or strongly agree*).

1. How important is stable housing to your ability to avoid future legal trouble?

Rationale: This question assesses whether housing is perceived as a core protective factor in desistance and stabilization.

2. How important is access to mental health services in a residential program?

Rationale: This item evaluates the perceived need for clinical support and emotional stabilization.

3. How important is help with employment or job readiness?

Rationale: Employment is often central to reentry success and independent functioning.

4. How important is educational support, such as GED assistance or college planning?

Rationale: This item captures the need for academic advancement and future orientation.

5. How important is life-skills training (budgeting, cooking, transportation, time management)?

Rationale: This item assesses demand for practical independent living support.

6. How important is substance use support or relapse prevention programming?

Rationale: This question identifies the need for addiction-related services when relevant.

7. How likely would you be to participate in a residential program that combines structure with increasing independence?

Rationale: This item assesses acceptability of the proposed model.

8. How concerned would you be about rules in a residential program feeling too restrictive?

Rationale: This question helps identify engagement barriers and possible resistance to programming.

9. How important is staff who understand trauma and avoid judgment?

Rationale: This item evaluates the perceived importance of relational safety and trauma-informed practice.

10. How important is family support or mediation services when appropriate?

Rationale: This question captures whether family reconnection or systems support should be integrated.

Qualitative Questions for Emerging Adults

1. What are the biggest challenges facing young adults like you when trying to stay out of trouble and build a stable life?

Rationale: This broad opening question identifies perceived core needs and barriers in participants' own language.

2. What kinds of services or supports would make the biggest difference during this stage of life?

Rationale: This question helps identify desired program components.

3. What has made it hard to use services that were available in the past?

Rationale: This item explores engagement barriers, such as mistrust, transportation, stigma, or inflexible rules.

4. If you lived in a residential support program, what would help it feel useful and respectful rather than controlling?

Rationale: This question directly informs program culture and implementation.

5. What would make someone your age decide not to join or stay in a program like this?

Rationale: This question is designed to identify dropout risks and program design weaknesses.

6. What does success look like for someone leaving a program like this?

Rationale: This item helps define meaningful outcomes from the participant perspective.

Quantitative Questions for Professional Stakeholders

Professional stakeholders may also complete brief scaled items.

1. To what extent is there a gap in residential or transitional services for justice-involved emerging adults in your community?

Rationale: This item assesses perceived system-level need.

2. How important is integrated mental health treatment within a residential model?

Rationale: This question measures perceived value of embedded clinical care.

3. How important is vocational and educational programming for this population?

Rationale: This assesses whether stakeholders view skill-building as essential.

4. How feasible is cross-system collaboration among justice, mental health, and community providers?

Rationale: This item identifies implementation feasibility concerns.

5. How concerned are you about participant engagement and retention in a residential program?

Rationale: This question assesses anticipated barriers to successful participation.

Qualitative Questions for Professional Stakeholders

1. What are the most significant unmet needs you observe among justice-involved emerging adults?

Rationale: This question identifies recurring service gaps from the professional perspective.

2. What limitations do you see in the current service system?

Rationale: This item helps identify structural barriers that justify the proposed program.

3. What program elements would be most essential for a residential model serving this population?

Rationale: This question informs core program design.

4. What barriers might prevent implementation or long-term success of this program?

Rationale: This item surfaces operational and organizational risks.

5. How should program success be measured?

Rationale: This question identifies meaningful outcomes from a systems and practice perspective.

Data Collection Procedures

After informed consent is obtained, participants will complete a brief demographic form and quantitative rating items. Focus groups will then be conducted using a semi-structured guide tailored to each participant group. The emerging adult and professional stakeholder groups will be conducted separately in order to support psychological safety, reduce power differentials, and encourage candid discussion.

Each focus group is expected to last approximately 60 to 90 minutes. Sessions may be audio recorded with permission and supplemented by facilitator notes documenting key themes,

group dynamics, and contextual observations. Data should be stored securely in password-protected files, and identifying information should be separated from response data whenever possible.

Data Analysis

Quantitative Analysis

Quantitative items will be analyzed using descriptive statistics. Means, frequencies, and standard deviations may be calculated to identify which service needs and program components are rated as most important by each participant group. These results can be used to compare patterns across emerging adult and stakeholder respondents and to highlight the strongest areas of perceived need.

Qualitative Analysis: Thematic Analysis

Qualitative focus group data will be analyzed using thematic analysis. This approach is appropriate because it allows the researcher to identify, organize, and interpret patterns of meaning across participant responses while remaining flexible enough for applied program development work.

The thematic analysis process may include the following steps:

1. **Familiarization with the data.** Audio recordings will be transcribed, reviewed, and read multiple times.
2. **Initial coding.** Segments of text will be labeled based on meaningful content related to needs, barriers, preferences, and program recommendations.
3. **Searching for themes.** Codes will be grouped into broader categories representing patterns across responses.
4. **Reviewing themes.** Candidate themes will be refined to ensure they are coherent, distinct, and supported by the data.
5. **Defining and naming themes.** Final themes will be clearly articulated and linked to the purpose of the needs assessment.

6. Integrating findings. Qualitative themes will be interpreted alongside quantitative results to provide a fuller account of participant needs and program implications.

Potential themes may include housing instability, mistrust of systems, need for trauma-informed care, importance of structure balanced with autonomy, barriers to employment, and need for relational support. These examples are illustrative only; actual themes should emerge from the data.

Validity and Trustworthiness

In mixed-methods needs assessment work, validity is strengthened by using multiple sources of information and clearly linking research questions to data collection methods. In this proposed chapter, validity is supported by collecting both quantitative and qualitative data, obtaining perspectives from both intended service users and professional stakeholders, and using semi-structured procedures that allow consistency across groups while preserving flexibility for richer exploration.

For the qualitative component, trustworthiness may be supported through several strategies. First, the use of an interview or focus group guide increases procedural consistency. Second, reflexive note-taking can help the researcher identify potential biases and assumptions during analysis. Third, peer review or committee review of codes and themes may improve credibility. Fourth, the inclusion of direct participant quotations in the final write-up can strengthen transparency by showing how findings are grounded in the data.

For the quantitative component, content validity is supported when items are directly aligned with the purpose of the needs assessment and the key domains of the proposed program. Pilot review by a dissertation chair, committee member, or subject matter expert may further improve clarity and relevance of items before administration.

Summary

This chapter presented a mock needs assessment chapter for a proposed residential program serving justice-involved or otherwise high-risk emerging adults. The chapter introduced the proposed program, explained the scope of the chapter, identified two focus groups, described

recruitment and selection procedures, reviewed informed consent considerations, presented quantitative and qualitative questions with rationales, and outlined a plan for descriptive and thematic data analysis. It also described strategies to support validity and trustworthiness. As a dissertation component, this type of chapter provides a structured foundation for understanding stakeholder-informed program need and for guiding later recommendations regarding program design, implementation, and evaluation.

Optional Layout Notes for Final Dissertation Formatting

Depending on institutional guidelines, the final chapter may also include:

- A chapter title page or formatted chapter heading
- Running heads or page headers if required
- Table(s) summarizing participant demographics
- Appendix materials for recruitment flyers, consent forms, and full questionnaires
- A brief transition paragraph into the next chapter
- Citations throughout the chapter to support claims about emerging adulthood, desistance, trauma-informed care, and residential programming